because I'd refused the stuff. The whole system is rigged to punish people who have different ideas of how things should be done.

I don't have the gene that helps you to help yourself. And that lack would cause trouble for me all the way down the line. But I can't make too many apologies for that: I was, and always will be, more concerned with the wars going on around the world than with making things easier for myself. It soon became clear that WikiLeaks would have a crucial role in throwing some true light onto these wars when, in the autumn and winter of 2007, we received a number of documents that had come from deep inside the US military. In November we published this incredible database that revealed all the military equipment that has been registered by the US Army for use in Iraq, about 150,000 records. I made an analysis of the material and saw that what it amounted to was what is called 'the order of battle', the whole pyramidal planning system, detailing each unit, their name and everything they had; not expendables like bullets, but fixed-down stuff like Persian rugs and computers. I took the complete list and wrote a computer program to analyse it: looking at a military supply site and getting the prices, we were able to get a sense of both the giant costs and which units had been the best-funded. About half of all equipment purchases had been focused on dealing with insurgents' improvised explosive devices, most commonly called roadside bombs or IEDs. Most of this money was being spent on 'warlock' machines, which are very sophisticated jammers of radio signals. The total money spent on evading IEDs – on detectors, jammers, robot defusers, extra armour and so on – amounted to about $13 billion. Even if you adjust the figure for inflation, that's more than the entire cost of the Manhattan Project, and something I believe the world has a right to know.

It was like setting up scaffolding for lots of new and deeper stories about what was actually happening in Iraq and Afghanistan. Reporters, generally, were taking too much for granted; no one was asking where the money was going and how the command structure worked.

New material began flooding towards us and I could see the change it might bring about. We were going to crack the world open and let it flower into something new. Yet we found early on what the struggles were going to be, and one of the biggest, one of the most persistent, was to do with journalists' apathy. You could open up all these new lines of enquiry, these new routes to justice, and they would just shrug and say they didn't have the time to work through the material. It was frustrating. But I now see it as